# Building an AI Engineer Resume

A complete guide to structure, content, and presentation

*Companion handout to the Career Launch session. Pair it with the sample resume, then rebuild your own from the checklist on the last page.*

**What's inside**


- How your resume actually gets read
- The one-page structure, in order
- A section-by-section breakdown of what to write
- The bullet-point formula that gets interviews
- What to include, what to leave off, and how to format it
- Tailoring, common mistakes, and a final checklist


## 1. How your resume actually gets read

Before a single human reads your resume closely, it usually passes through two fast filters. Designing for both is the whole game.

**The recruiter scan.** A recruiter spends only a handful of seconds on the first pass, skimming the top third for your title, your most recent role, and a few keywords. If nothing lands, they move on. Put your strongest, most relevant signal high on the page.

**The ATS (Applicant Tracking System).** Most mid-to-large companies run resumes through software that parses your text into fields and matches it against the job description before a person sees it. Fancy layouts confuse the parser. A clean, single-column document with standard headings reads reliably.

**The takeaway:** write for a skim and a parser first, and a careful human second. Lead with impact, use standard structure, and mirror the language of the job posting.

## 2. The one-page structure, in order

For an early-career AI engineer, this order puts your strongest evidence where it gets seen. Keep it to one page.

- **Header & contact** — name, target title, and links (email, LinkedIn, GitHub, portfolio).
- **Summary** — two or three lines framing who you are and what you want.
- **Technical skills** — grouped by category so both recruiters and the ATS find keywords fast.
- **Experience** — roles with quantified, impact-first bullets.
- **Projects** — often your strongest evidence as a bootcamp grad; treat it like a core section, not an afterthought.
- **Education & certifications** — bootcamp, degree, and relevant credentials.

***Note on order:*** *if your projects are stronger than your work history (common for career changers), place Projects above Experience. Lead with whatever makes the best case.*

## 3. Section by section

### Header & contact

Keep it to two or three lines. Include your name, the exact title you're targeting, and links. Make every link clickable and live.

- **Use your target title** (“AI / Machine Learning Engineer”), not your current job title, if they differ.
- Include LinkedIn, GitHub, and a portfolio or personal site. These are the first things a recruiter clicks.
- Use a professional email. City and state are enough — no full street address.
- Don't add a photo, date of birth, or other personal details (the norm in the US; it can also confuse the ATS).

### Professional summary

Two to three lines, not a paragraph. State what you are, your core stack, and the kind of role you want. Front-load keywords. Skip vague traits like “hard-working team player.”

**Example:** *“Machine learning engineer with a background in data analytics, specializing in building and deploying end-to-end ML and LLM-powered systems in Python and PyTorch. Track record of shipping models that move business metrics.”*

### Technical skills

Group skills into labeled categories so they're scannable and keyword-rich. A flat alphabetical list is harder to read and easier to skim past.

- Suggested groups: Languages; ML & Deep Learning; LLMs & GenAI; MLOps & Deployment; Cloud & Data.
- List tools you can actually discuss in an interview. Every item here is fair game for a question.
- Mirror the job description's wording — if it says “PyTorch,” don't only write “torch.”
- Skip self-rated proficiency bars; they take space and mean little to a reader.

### Experience

Lead each bullet with impact, not responsibility. Recruiters care about what changed because you were there. Use the bullet formula in the next section, and keep three to five bullets per recent role.

- List roles in reverse-chronological order; put the title first, then company and dates.
- Non-AI experience still counts — frame it toward transferable, technical, and measurable work (a career changer's analytics or engineering background is an asset).
- Use past tense for previous roles and present tense for your current one.

### Projects

For a bootcamp grad, projects are often the most convincing proof you can build and ship. Treat each like a mini work entry: what you built, the result, and the stack.

- Show two to three projects that are finished, deployed, and ideally have a live demo or link.
- Quantify wherever possible — latency, accuracy, dataset size, users, BLEU/F1, cost saved.
- Link directly to the repo, and make sure that repo has a strong README (problem, approach, results, demo).
- Name the tech stack on its own line so the keywords are easy to spot.

### Education & certifications

List your bootcamp and degree with dates. Add relevant certifications (e.g., a cloud ML credential). Keep coursework off unless a class maps directly to the target role.

## 4. The bullet-point formula

A strong bullet follows a simple pattern: **Action verb + what you built / how + a metric + the outcome.**

**Before**

> *"Built a machine learning model to predict customer churn using Python."*

**After**

> *"Built a churn-prediction model (XGBoost) that improved recall **18%** on **500K** records, flagging **$1.2M** of at-risk revenue."*

**No numbers yet?** Estimate honestly. Think in terms of time saved, scale handled, error reduced, users reached, or money affected. A defensible approximation ("~15 hours/week," "40+ stakeholders") beats a vague claim.

**Strong action verbs to open bullets:**

| Build & ship | Improve & optimize | ML-specific |
|---|---|---|
| Built, Shipped, Deployed, Engineered, Developed, Launched, Productionized | Optimized, Reduced, Accelerated, Improved, Automated, Streamlined, Scaled | Trained, Fine-tuned, Benchmarked, Evaluated, Deployed, Integrated, Served |

## 5. What to include — and what to leave off

| Include | Leave off |
|---|---|
| Target title and clickable links | Photo, age, marital status, full address |
| Quantified, impact-first bullets | Duty lists ("responsible for…") with no outcome |
| Grouped, keyword-rich skills | Skill-rating bars or long flat lists |
| 2–3 deployed projects with links | Unfinished or empty placeholder repos |

| | |
|---|---|
| Bootcamp, degree, relevant certs | Every course you ever took |
| References available on request? — skip it; it's assumed | An “Objective” that only says what you want |

## 6. Formatting & presentation

### Keep it parser-safe

- One page, single column. Multi-column layouts and sidebars often scramble in the ATS.
- Use standard section headings (Experience, Skills, Projects) so fields map correctly.
- Don't put contact info in the header/footer region — some parsers skip it. Keep it in the body.
- Avoid tables, text boxes, and images for layout; they can break parsing. (Tables are fine in a guide like this, not in the resume itself.)

### Make it readable

- A clean font (Arial, Calibri, Cambria) at 10–11pt body; name larger.
- Consistent spacing, dates, and tense throughout. Inconsistency reads as carelessness.
- Generous margins (0.5–0.75”) and white space; don't cram.
- At most one or two accent colors. Keep body text dark for contrast.

### Save and name it right

- **Export as PDF** unless the posting asks for .docx — PDF preserves your layout everywhere.
- Name the file professionally: **Firstname_Lastname_Resume.pdf** — not “resume_final_v3.pdf.”

## 7. Tailor it to each job

A generic resume is easy to skim past. Spend ten minutes per application adjusting it to the posting.

- Pull the recurring skills and phrases from the job description and make sure the matching ones appear (truthfully) in your skills and bullets.
- Reorder bullets and skills so the most relevant ones sit first.
- Adjust your summary line to echo the role's focus (e.g., LLMs vs. computer vision vs. MLOps).
- Never invent skills to match — you will be asked about anything on the page.

## 8. Common mistakes to avoid

- Listing duties instead of results — every bullet should answer “so what?”
- Burying projects at the bottom when they're your best evidence.

- Linking a GitHub full of empty or unfinished repos. Curate before you link.
- Spelling/grammar slips, inconsistent dates, or a mismatched tense.
- Spilling onto a second page to keep low-value content. Cut instead.
- Claiming tools you can't discuss. If it's on the page, you can be quizzed on it.

## 9. Final pre-send checklist

- Fits on one page, single column, standard headings.
- Target title and all links present, clickable, and correct.
- Every experience and project bullet has a metric or concrete outcome.
- Skills are grouped and mirror the job description's wording.
- 2–3 deployed projects, each linked to a repo with a strong README.
- Consistent dates, tense, fonts, and spacing throughout.
- Proofread end to end (and read it once out loud).
- Saved as **Firstname_Lastname_Resume.pdf** and tailored to this specific role.

*You've done the hard part — now make it impossible to overlook.*